imposing Arabism on the territory and its citizens. I think it would be correct to say that Iranian identity—at least until Khomeini's revolution in 1979—was ethnic first and foremost, rather than religious. In fact, even since the 1979 coup, it is very difficult to say that there is true religious solidarity between the Iranians and the Muslim world, especially since Iran is Shiite—even if there is some degree of solidarity, it is with Islam's Shiite minority.

A close look at Iran since the revolution leads me to conclude that the religious establishment that currently dominates Iran attributes more importance to Muslim religious identity than to ethnic identity. Had ethnic identity been of supreme importance, it is doubtful whether a man like Khamenei, whose ethnic origin is Azeri and not Persian, would have attained the status of the all-powerful spiritual leader. The Khomeini revolution symbolized, more than anything, the hatred of those who flew the banner of religion toward the secular regime of the shah, who encouraged Western modernity.

There is no doubt that one of the roots, and perhaps the biggest factor, of the profound hatred of Israel is the fact that the shah, who had exiled Khomeini from his country, was a very close ally of Israel.

During the 1960s, the period that we served in Iran, within the consciousness of the Iranian intelligentsia, the world was divided into Germany and all the rest. An Iranian traveling abroad would try to begin his journey in Germany; there was a very large German presence in Iran, a big embassy, a Goethe-Institut for the study of the German language, German restaurants, German investments, and strong economic and commercial ties. There is no doubt that all of this can be explained by the sense of shared ethnic identity between the Iranians and the Germans. There were, however, also common geostrategic interests between them.

This is the place to mention that Reza Shah, the father of the last shah of the Pahlavi dynasty, who ruled Iran from 1925 to 1941, was so pro-Nazi that the Allies exiled him to South Africa and crowned his son Muhammad Reza in his stead. A few years later, in 1951, Dr. Mohammad Mossadegh was elected prime minister of Iran and nationalized Iran's oil industry. The Western powers refused to relinquish their influence in a country as important as Iran, and the CIA orchestrated a military coup against Mossadegh, which failed and forced the shah to flee his country. In 1953 the CIA organized a second, this time successful, military coup, which was